

Cashflow2.0 — App Store, Play Store & Microsoft Store Deployment Guide

A practical, step-by-step path to publishing on all three major app stores, plus a Windows desktop app, with realistic timelines and common rejection triggers to plan around.

1. Overview: timelines and cost at a glance

These figures are current estimates based on 2026 store policy and typical review behaviour, not guarantees — Apple and Google both adjust rules periodically.

Store	Developer account cost	Realistic first-launch timeline	Review time (later updates)
Google Play	\$25 one-time	2–3 weeks (new accounts — dominated by mandatory testing period, not review itself)	1–3 days
Apple App Store	\$99/year	3–7 days typical for new accounts; can extend for finance-category apps	24–48 hours
Microsoft Store (via PWA)	Free or small one-time fee depending on account type	Days, not weeks — no separate native build required	24–48 hours, often same-day

A note on the existing codebase: since the app was built in React Native, both the iOS and Android submissions build from the same underlying codebase — this is not two separate rewrites. What differs between them is the platform-specific build and submission pipeline each store requires, covered separately below.

2. Google Play Store — full path

2.1 Step-by-step

1. Build the Android release: run the project's existing build tooling (e.g. an EAS build) targeting Android, producing a signed .aab file (Android App Bundle — the required format; a plain .apk is not accepted for new listings).
2. Create a Google Play Console developer account — \$25 one-time fee, with identity verification required before the account is usable.
3. If this is a new personal developer account (created after November 2023): run a closed test with at least 12 testers, opted in and actively using the app for 14 continuous days, before Google will allow an application for production access. This step cannot be skipped or sped up, and is the single biggest factor in the overall timeline.
4. Prepare the store listing: app title, description, a 512x512 icon, a feature graphic, and at least 2 screenshots.
5. Complete the Data Safety declaration, describing exactly what data the app collects and how it is used or shared — this must accurately reflect real behaviour (e.g. transaction data storage, use of Gemini for categorisation).
6. Set the target API level in the build configuration — API 35 at minimum currently, rising to API 36 as a hard requirement from 31 August 2026.
7. Once the 14-day closed test is complete, apply for production access — Google typically responds within 7 days.
8. Final app review before the listing goes fully live — typically 1–3 days.

Total realistic estimate for a first launch: 2–3 weeks, with the 14-day testing window as the dominant factor rather than the review itself.

2.2 What “closed testing with 12+ testers for 14 continuous days” actually means

Google requires real people — not automated accounts — to install the app via a private, invite-only link inside Play Console, and to actively use it (not merely install it and leave it untouched) for 14 uninterrupted days before Google will grant permission to publish publicly at all. Testers can be friends or family added by email address; Google's system checks that they are genuinely opted in and engaging with the app, not simply present on a list. This exists to reduce spam and low-quality submissions, and applies to every new personal developer account with no way to opt out or shorten it.

2.3 What a “Privacy Policy URL” means

A real, published web page — not a document sent privately — describing what data the app collects, how it is stored, and who (if anyone) it is shared with. Both Google and Apple require this. For this app, a short page covering: transaction data storage, the use of Google's Gemini API for categorisation, and a statement that data is not sold or shared with third parties, would satisfy this — this could simply be a page added to the existing deployed website.

2.4 What a “Feature Graphic” means

A single wide promotional banner image, 1024x500 pixels, displayed prominently at the top of the Play Store listing page. It is distinct from the app icon and from screenshots — think of it as the equivalent of a header/cover image for the listing, generally showing the app's branding or a key screen.

2.5 Common rejection triggers to plan around

- Requesting permissions without a clearly justified, user-facing purpose in the listing — every permission needs a stated reason.
- A Data Safety declaration that doesn't match the app's actual behaviour — Google cross-checks this against real usage.
- Missing working reviewer login credentials for a login-gated app such as this one — a valid test account must be supplied.

3. Apple App Store — full path

3.1 Step-by-step

9. Enroll in the Apple Developer Program — \$99/year. Financial apps specifically may need to enroll as an Organization account rather than an Individual account; confirm this early, since switching account types later is a slow, disruptive process.
10. Build the iOS release via Xcode, using the same underlying React Native codebase as the Android build: set the build scheme to Release, select “Any iOS Device” as the target, then Product -> Archive.
11. Validate the archive in Xcode's Organizer window, then choose Distribute App -> App Store Connect -> Upload.
12. Ensure the build targets the current required SDK — as of 28 April 2026, submissions must use the iOS 26 SDK or newer.
13. Prepare the App Store Connect listing: screenshots, description, a published privacy policy URL, and the App Privacy “nutrition label” disclosures covering exactly what data is collected.

14. Provide working demo login credentials in the Review Notes section — Apple's reviewers will not create their own account, so a valid username and password must be supplied and must work the moment review begins, with any two-factor/SMS verification disabled for that specific test account.
 15. Submit for review — typically 24–48 hours; first-time submissions or apps in sensitive categories (finance included) can take 3–7 days.
 16. If rejected: Apple's response arrives via the Resolution Center as a message citing the specific guideline violated, in the same thread (not a new ticket). Reply once the issue is fixed — most rejections are resolvable within 24–72 hours of the original notice.
- Roughly 1 in 4 first submissions across the App Store overall are rejected on the first attempt — this is worth budgeting for as the realistic norm, not an exception, rather than assuming a clean first pass.

3.2 The single most common rejection cause for a login-gated app like this one

Guideline 2.1 (“App Completeness”) — a reviewer being unable to actually access or test the app's real functionality. Since this app requires login, a working demo account with a genuine username and password must be supplied directly in the Review Notes, and any two-factor/SMS step must be disabled specifically for that account — a reviewer will not attempt to work around a live 2FA prompt, and the submission will simply be rejected as incomplete.

4. Microsoft Store — via PWA

This is the fastest and lowest-friction of the three paths, because it does not require building or maintaining a separate native codebase at all — it packages the existing website directly.

4.1 Step-by-step

17. Ensure the website meets basic PWA requirements: a web app manifest file, a service worker, and HTTPS (already in place via the current deployment).
18. Create a personal Microsoft account and enroll it in the Windows Developer Program via Microsoft Partner Center.
19. Reserve an app name in Partner Center — this reservation expires after 3 months if unused, so time this close to actual submission.
20. Go to PWABuilder.com and enter the site's live URL — it audits the site and reports whether it is store-ready, with an Action Items list if not.
21. Once ready, click “Package For Stores”, then generate the Windows package — this produces a .msixbundle and a .classic.appxbundle file. No code changes are required; this is generated automatically from the live site.
22. Upload the generated package to Partner Center and complete the store listing (description, screenshots, icon).
23. Submit for review — typically 24–48 hours, often same-day.

Total realistic estimate for a first launch: days, not weeks — by far the fastest of the three stores, since there is no separate native build, no mandatory testing period, and no platform-specific codebase to maintain going forward.

5. Desktop app — directly tied to the PWA work

A Progressive Web App is, by design, installable as a genuine desktop app — with its own window, taskbar icon, and app-switcher presence — on Windows, and on macOS/Linux via any Chromium-based browser. This means the Microsoft Store submission in Section 4 effectively is the Windows desktop app; there is no separate desktop-specific build to create.

Practically, this means the single PWA upgrade already discussed in the main migration report serves three goals at once: the “add to home screen” experience on phones, the Microsoft Store listing covered above, and a genuine Windows desktop app — all from the same piece of work, rather than three separate projects.

End of document.